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Bad Detective

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Bad Detective

Detective: (to audience) It had been a fairly quiet evening. I was at my desk, busy doing online image searches in a desperate attempt to self-diagnose the papules that had recently appeared on my undercarriage when suddenly, fate walked right through my door.

(Charlotte enters)

Charlotte: Knock knock! Hello there.

(Detective starts clicking frantically and typing on his computer, trying to quickly think up an excuse for what he's doing)

Detective: OH! Hey hi sorry I was just uh…looking at…uh, porn…ography. Wait, thats not…what can I do you for?

Charlotte: Are you Detective Shlackalugglеberginsteinson?

Detective: She had eyes that could cut a diamond; legs that could make the strawberries in the fridge go bad; boobies that were…super nice. I'm talking, like, really nice boobs.

(Detective as began ogling her and has forgot to respond to her question)

Charlotte: Detective Shlackalugglеberginsteinson?

Detective: Oh uh please, Detective Shlackalugglеberginsteinson was my father's name. Call me Burt.

Charlotte: Well, Burt, I have to say, I barely recognized you. You're much more handsome in person than you are in your picture.

(Charlotte holds up a copy of Detective's ad - his picture is extremely hideous)

Detective: Haha, you flatter me. Now what can I do you for Miss-

Charlotte: Mrs. actually. But you can just call me Charlotte. I'm here because I think my husband is wrapped up with some questionable people.

Detective: Oh yeah? Possibly some gays, huh?

Charlotte: Excuse me?

Detective: Gay people. You know…maybe he's going out on ya.

Charlotte: Um…no, that wasn't the implication.

Detective: Oh, sorry, I was just, I'm sorry….Please, tell me more about your husband's situation.

Charlotte: Well- it all started a few weeks ago when he came home all bloody and beaten up. I tried to ask him what happened but I couldn't get a straight answer out of him. He had some loose narrative about slipping and falling, but I heard him on the phone talking about this man with shaky arms. Now I can't find him! He seems to have skipped town and I don't know if he's alive or if he…

(Detective fades Charlotte out and starts monologuing)

Detective: (to audience) The woman had quite the way with words; the kind that made your mind wander off and get distracted about halfway through her sentences. I just hoped that my unabashed homophobic tendencies didn't get in the way of our newfound working relationship.

Charlotte: Are you listening to me?

Detective: What? I'm sorry. I was monologuing in my head. Can you repeat what you were saying?

Charlotte: You don't seem like a very good detective.

Detective: Well, things aren't always as they seem, are they Miss…oh god, what's your name again?

Charlotte: Charlotte.

Detective: That's right! Charlotte. Sorry, I'm not great with names.

Charlotte: I was saying that my husband has disappeared. I need your help to find out where he is and if, god forbid, he's still even breathing.

Detective: Shecky Charlotte. Shacky…shimmy Charlotte.

Charlotte: What?

Detective: Sorry, I'm trying to come up with a pneumonic device so I can remember your name. Sha, sho, shopping, shoulder- shoulder! Shoulder Charlotte! Hey that's a pretty good one.

Charlotte: Okay, can we-

Detective: Cause you got shoulders and your name is Charlotte. So when I see someone with shoulders, I'll think, "Hey! That must be Charlotte…"

Charlotte: Burt, I'm sorry, but I don't think this is going to work out-

Detective: Oh what, no! Please! I need this. I haven't had a client in weeks!

Charlotte: If you think you can help then go ahead, but you aren't getting a single dime until I get some answers. Deal?

Detective: (to audience) I was in a little bit of a sticky wicket. I needed the money, but the chances of me solving this case were slim to none. None to none even, but that-

Charlotte: Burt!

Detective: What? Yeah, sorry. What?

Charlotte: Here. This is a picture of my husband.

(Charlotte hands Detective a picture)

Detective: Wow, he's a lot blacker than I had him pinned.

Charlotte: He frequents the Bitter End, the bar down on Rush street. I'd go myself, but they'd recognize me in an instant. It's not safe for me. Like I said, I've heard him talk elusively about someone they call the man with shaky arms. I have a feeling that if you find the man with the shaky arms, you'll be able to figure out what happened to my husband.

Detective: That's boring. I don't want to do all that.

Charlotte: Please, Burt. I need help. Good private eyes in this town are hard to come by.

Detective: Well, I'm not a good private eye. I'm a great private eye, Sharon.

Charlotte: Charlotte.

Detective: Charlotte.

(to the audience)

Detective: That night, I decided to check out the bar that Cheryl had mentioned. I had been planning to go to a bar anyway, as I'm a passably functional alcoholic with a heart full of bigotry and self-hatred, so I decided I might as well do something constructive for my case while I was at it.

Bartender: Hey. Whatcha having?

Detective: Let me get a beer. Double shot of vodka in it please.

Bartender: What?

Detective: Haha, just a joke between old friends - say you wouldn't happen to know this black guy would you?

(Detective hands Bartender the picture)

Bartender: I don't know, maybe…why do you ask?

Detective: We can talk about it after you get my vodka beer. Put some ice in it too, would ya? Just know I'm trying to keep a low profile, not call attention to myself, ya got me?

Bartender: Uh yeah sure.

Detective: What am I saying…this guy knows about low profiles. Am I right?

(Detective slaps the bartender on the shoulder and starts looking around the bar for backup)

Detective: Huh? Am I right! Anybody? This guy knows what I'm talking about. Right? Huh? Do you know what I'm talking about? What about you two, you guys know what I'm talking about? You two guys? On the stools down there. I'm trying to keep a low profile! Say, you guys aren't gay are you? Is this a gay bar? I don't ask because I'm gay. I am only asking because I'm highly intolerant.

Bartender: Hey man you gotta relax a little bit. Quit yelling so much.

Detective: Hey, it's all good! I'm cool, bro, I'm cool. We're all old friends here. Isn't that right gay fellows!?

Bartender: Look, is there a reason you decided to come in here today and act all high and mighty and intolerant of Hank and Baxter's life choices?

Hank: It's not a choice.

Baxter: Damn straight.

Detective: My apologies. I don't want any trouble. I'm just trying to drink my icy vodka beer and find out who this black guy is, okay?

Bartender: If I tell you will you promise to shut up and get out of my bar?

Detective: (to audience) Well well well…looks like my affixation on race and sexual orientation was finally starting to pay off. But it wasn't all good news. Turns out some of these people didn't really agree with my view points all that much. I was sensing a little hostility from the regulars, and by the looks of the bartender, he wasn't too happy with me either. Then again, I wasn't very happy with me. You see, I came from a very old-fashioned upbringing, one where the decisions of others are seen as religiously and morally inferior to that of your own-

Bartender: Hey! Are you listening to me?

Detective: Sorry! Sorry, I was zoning out pretty hard. I'm self-diagnosed with attention deficit syndrome.

Bartender: I don't think that's a syndrome.

Detective: Well I know there's a lot of doubters out there but there's enough science at this point to back that A.D.S. is a real thing.

Bartender: Look, the guy's name is Anthony. He used to be a regular here before getting in deep with a few of the sports bookies. Particularly, the Shaky Arms Man. Shaky roughed him up pretty good. Word on the street is Anthony even skipped town. Haven't seen him in here for a week or two. But listen you go around showing people that picture and you're going to be guilty by association, you understand? Now I'd tuck that away in your pocket and go home before you get your teeth knocked in over a guy you don't know, and that's probably the best advice you are gonna here all night. You got it?

(Detective seems to be monologuing in his head, mouthing words to himself while neglecting to catch anything the bartender has just disclosed to him)

Bartender: Jesus-

Detective: Wha- OH man, sorry, sorry. I definitely was doing it again.

Bartender: Listen man, I tried to help you but you're on your own.

Detective: Wait- could you just repeat all that-!

(Bartender exits)

Detective: (to audience) Damn- What a shame…the case had fallen right into my lap, but I was too busy looking at stuff that wasn't my lap to notice. I had almost given up hope when suddenly…I saw him.

(Detective sees someone at the bar. He carefully approaches him)

Detective: Um, excuse me. Sir? You wouldn't happen to be, the Shaky Arms Man, would you?

(Shaky Arms Man's arms shake violently)

Shaky: Depends. Whose asking?

Detective: (To audience) Well as fate would have it, the Shaky Arms Man was back in my lap again, and I liked him in my lap. Not sexually speaking of course, that didn't come out right…am I gay?

Detective: (shivering off his internal discussion) Um yes, well, the name's Shlackaluggleberginsteinson. Burt Shlackaluggleberginsteinson.

Shaky: That's the silliest name I ever heard. You aren't a cop are ya?

Detective: No I'm a detective-- I mean…no.

Shaky: Okay good. I don't like pigs or narcs or private dicks up in my business.

Detective: With you loud and clear on that one.

Shaky: You see, I'm a well-established bookie in this town and the thought of someone, whether they be a pig or a narc or a private dick, the thought of someone interfering with my business makes me feel pretty stabby!

Detective: Stabby? Is that an emotion of some kind or…?

Shaky: It's the only emotion where I'm from.

Detective: That's interesting. You see, I was unaware of that, as most of my

knowledge of human emotion stems from studying the various emojis that I find on my phone, and I don't think there's one for "stabby" or at least not currently there isn't…

Shaky: Look, I like you kid. You got a real trustworthy vibe to you. Let me buy you a drink. What are you having? Barkeep!

Bartender: Yeah Shaky?

Shaky: Get this man a drink! I'll have whatever he's having!

Detective: Make it a Capris Sun and gin please, barkeep.

Bartender: We don't have that.

Detective: Capris Sun and tequila then?

Bartender: We don't have Capris Sun.

Detective: Okay well just another vodka beer on the rocks then please.

Shaky: Oh, god, that's, really…okay, yeah sure, make it two.

(Bartender serves them some Vodka beers)

Shaky: To new friends.

Detective: To new friends.

(They cheers their glasses and take a sip. Shaky Arms Man is disgusted by his drink)

Detective: Say, now that we're old pals and I'm not a detective or anything, you wouldn't happen to know this man would you.

(Bartender makes a cutting motion to his neck as Detective reaches into his pocket. Detective neglects to understand the hand motion and produces the picture of Anthony anyway. He holds it up for Shaky to see).

Detective: He's the black one.

Shaky: There's only one guy in this picture.

Detective: And?

Shaky: Hey wait a minute….I do know him! Hey this guy owes me a lot of money! What!? Is he one of your friends or something! If he ended up being one of your friends that'd make me pretty stabby.

Detective: Oh no, no sir. I- uh-

(Detective quickly puts the picture away. Bartender rolls his eyes.)

Shaky: What you come to get revenge for me and my boys beating him half dead last week!?

Detective: No, no sir…I was just hired to-

Shaky: HIRED!? So what then!? You're a private dick?

Detective: No no no, no dicks here! I swear!

Shaky: Bartender! Can you step in back for a second, me and my boys have to take care of a little business.

Bartender: Yes of course Shaky. Just try not to make a mess.

Shaky: Sure thing boss!

(Bartender exits)

Detective: No no no you got it all wrong Shaky! I'm not-

Shaky: Boys! Hold him down!

(The boys from the surrounding bar grab Detective and hold him down).

Detective: NO! NO NO! HELP! ANYONE! Gay fellows! Please! I'm sorry for everything! I have gay thoughts sometimes even!

Hank: You're on your own detective.

Baxter: Damn straight.

Detective: NOOOOOO!

(Shaky produces a big knife and stabs Detective repeatedly in the stomach).

Detective: AhhhHHHHHH! PLEASE NO STOP!!! OH MY GOD OH MY GOD-

Detective: (To audience) Of all the vodka beer joints in all the world, I had to get stabbed in this one. You know, for my entire life I wanted to be a detective and here I was, getting stabbed in what could possibly be a gay bar. Well, you know what they say- the grass is- uh, excuse me. Well, you know what they say, the green is always- *cough cough*, you know what they grass. The gay bar is always greener- well, you know grass is greener- that grass is suuuuper green. Man, I'm not feeling so…where did all this blood come from?

(Detective loses consciousness, slurring his words as he slowly passes out. His life flashes before his eyes).

Dad: Burt, you're going to grow up to be a great detective son.

Detective: Dad?

Mom: When you get older, I bet you're going to be the best detective there ever was.

Detective: Mom?

Teacher: You're special Burt. That's why you're in this special class.

Detective: Mrs. Teacher Lady?

Grandpa: Those homosexuals and minorities are decreasing the value of the American dollar!

Detective: Grandpapa?

Charlotte: You don't seem like a very good detective.

Detective: Who are you again?

Shaky: All that's in this guy's wallet is a coupon for a free appetizer at Chili's and an expired condom. What a waste of stab!

Detective: Shaky?

Shaky: Just leave him in the gutter to die. Let's get out of here boys!

Detective: Oh okay goodbye everybody…

(Detective closes his eyes and falls still. After a few moments of silence, we hear the familiar beep of a hospital life-support device.)

Doctor: Burt? Burt? Can you hear me?

(Detective wakes up slowly)

Detective: Wha- *cough cough* - where am I?

Doctor: I'm Dr. James Conrad. You're in the hospital Burt. Some people found you outside the Bitter End a few nights ago after having been stabbed over sixty times. You're lucky to be alive!

Detective: Wow, you're a doctor? But you're a black guy!

Doctor: Um, yes, okay, well… anyway, you're hanging in there. Seems like most of your vital organs are in a stable condition. We should be able to have you out of here in a couple of days, but you will be wheelchair bound for the foreseeable future. Don't worry though, my husband is actually a world-renowned physical therapist. I'm going to suggest you see him for a few months and he should have you back walking in no time.

Detective: Your husband? Well I'll be darned, a gay black guy saved my life! Thank you so much doc!

Doctor: It was my pleasure, but to be honest, your incessant use of qualifiers about race and sexual orientation are quickly making me regret my decision.

Detective: Haha, that's pretty funny doc.

Doctor: There's a woman here asking to see you. I'd usually suggest against it for someone in your condition but my concern for your well-being is beginning to wane.

Detective: What do you mean "wayne?" As in Lil Wayne? Come on homie, no rap talk right now. Let's keep it professional up in here. This is a hospital, not a Dem Franchise Boys concert, you know what I'm saying?

(Detective goes for the fist pump. Doctor is unamused and does not reciprocate the bump.)

Doctor: I'll send her in.

(Doctor exits. Shortly after, Charlotte enters the room)

Charlotte: Detective Shlackalugglеberginsteinson.

Detective: Oh hey Shoulders!

Charlotte: It's Charlotte. Listen, I'm sorry for how things unfolded at the Bitter End. I should have known better than to send you into such a dangerous environment, especially after realizing how incompetent you are as a detective.

Detective: Nahhhhhhh baby, it's all good. They got me patched up and gave me this cool black fellow to hang out with. You know how we do, haha! Say how'd you know to find me here?

Charlotte: Well, to be honest, directly after our meeting the other day in your office, I went and hired another private eye. He not only found out my husband is in Argentina evading a massive gambling debt, but also reported that my other detective had been stabbed multiple times after offending as many demographics as possible.

Detective: I mean, it was just the two demographics really…

Charlotte: I thought I'd come and give my apologies before catching my flight to South America. I'm not happy with my husband for his decisions, but he's still my husband and I still love him. Thanks for trying, but you really should look into other professions.

Detective: Don't thank me ma'am; it's the least I could do.

Charlotte: I know that's a figure of speech, but in these circumstances, I really believe that you did the least humanly possible in terms of helping me resolve this case.

Detective: Yeah, I'm glad I could help too. Now, as far as payment goes, I'm thinking maybe a thousand dollars? But I'd also settle for a fifty dollar gift card to a chain restaurant of my choice. Honestly, if you just bring me some good coupons or something, we'll call it square. I had one for a free appetizer at Chili's but I seem to have misplaced it…

Charlotte: Goodbye Burt. Get well soon.

Detective: Oh okay, goodbye Sharon!

Charlotte: It's Charlotte.

(Charlotte exits. Detective starts monologuing)

Detective: So everything ended up working out for the best. Cheryl found her man, the Shaky Arms Man got my free appetizer with the purchase of any entrée coupon, and I was left back right where I started, paralyzed from the waist down. Yep, funny how life goes some times. One minute you're in your office self-diagnosing the skin tags on the underside of your genitals, the next you're having your prejudices quickly extinguished by a gay black doctor. I don't know much about this crazy mixed up thing we call life. All I know is that I'm trying to make the best I can out of it.